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WINDING DOWN

After surgery on my left hand in London in July 2013, I worked hard on getting back to full fitness. It was painful and time-consuming and it was a great relief to be able to resume practice by the end of August, some weeks ahead of the Champions League Twenty20. However, the period of recuperation was never boring. When I'd got back from England my friends Atul Ranade, Faisal Momen and I decided to start cycling as a part of my cardio exercise. Atul was already cycling on alternate days to stay fit, and Faisal decided to join in, making the whole thing more enjoyable. On the first day, after cycling for nearly forty minutes in the early morning, we decided to attempt the really steep incline that leads to the Mount Mary Church in Bandra. Faisal opted out when he saw the steepness of the slope, but Atul and I embarked on the climb. It was a difficult one, and by the time we reached the top we were both breathing heavily. I suggested repeating it, and Atul and I tried going up again. On the second attempt, I overtook Atul halfway up, but when I got to the top I started feeling seriously giddy. I tried drinking some water and did a few stretching exercises, but things did not improve and, by the time Atul had reached the top too, I was seeing white in front of my eyes and was forced to sit down on a divider on the road with my arms stretched out. In panic, Atul even started fanning me with a huge leaf that he plucked from a nearby tree! Things did not improve and I soon realized that what I really needed was to lie down to get the blood circulation back to my brain. When I told Atul, he saw an open-top jeep standing next to the church and, in desperation, suggested I lie down in it. That's when I spotted a rickshaw and asked Atul to persuade the driver to allow